



"THE THREE BIG ISSUES STARING AT US ARE GLOBAL TERROR, INTERNATIONAL FINANCIAL FRAGILITY AND THE ENVIRONMENTAL THREAT."

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In contrast to our troubled neighbour, we saw India's democracy working at its best in this decade. It was a period of political stability and rapid economic growth. The first part of the decade was ruled by India's first right wing government. Its arrival marked a historic shift in Indian politics, but the BJP government's inglorious finale proved that those who won that historic mandate were not worthy of it. In General Elections 2004, the defeat of the BJP was bigger than the victory of the Congress. The Congress alliance ruled gingerly for the full term with the pesky Left on its back. Five years later, India's Grand Old Party would retain power with a decisive victory which was attributed to the mother-son duo with the famous surname. The clear Congress mandate would magnify the leadership of our prime minister, who began as an accidental politician. The quiet ascent of Manmohan Singh as a leader in his own right was the most telling political narrative of the Indian decade. And the other was the self-destruction of a stalwart opposition leader.

Regardless of these political changes, the Indian economy was the star of the decade which grew at a compounded annual growth rate of 8.5 per cent. Mobile phone ownership crossed the 500 million mark, 18 motorbikes are sold a minute and now Indian companies continue to forage the international market for buyouts. Our country is teeming with amazing entrepreneurs and that's where I believe our future lies. All these positive developments, however, could not drive away India's status of a frontline victim state of jihad. Delhi, Ahmedabad, Jaipur, Hyderabad and, of course, 26/11 our 9/11. It was the day where we helplessly watched 10 terrorists hold a country to ransom for three days live on television. It was a national shame. Over the decade, terrorism has claimed 42,000 lives in India which is second only to Iraq. We have bled so much. That too without much resistance. With the legendary Indian sense of stoicism. It was as if the soft state had made a national virtue out of suffering. It was as if life was dispensable in a country under permanent